

BJARKE BUNDGAARD INGELS
Founder & Creative Partner, Bjarke Ingels Group

THE IDEA [BEHIND HEDONISTIC SUSTAINABILITY] IS THAT A SUSTAINABLE CITY OR BUILDING IS NOT ONLY BETTER FOR THE ENVIRONMENT, BUT IS ALSO MUCH MORE ENJOYABLE FOR THE PEOPLE THAT LIVE IN IT

Imagine the mindfulness city as a place where nature is enhanced rather than displaced by the city, where agriculture is integrated into the urban environment and where the tradition is very much alive and celebrated even in the contemporary architecture

PURSUIT OF HAPPINESS

Thinking 'big' comes naturally to Bjarke Bundgaard Ingels. The Danish architect who is the founder & creative partner of his eponymous Bjarke Ingels Group, or BIG, is one of the most sought-after man in the field of sustainable architecture and design. Speaking at the India Today Conclave, Ingels took the audience through his architectural journey, putting the spotlight on his ongoing work to create a "mindfulness city" in Bhutan.

To explain his style of design, which he calls "hedonistic sustainability", Ingels went back two decades to the Copenhagen Harbour Baths, a system of recreational bathing facilities along the waterfront, which "extended the life of the city into the water around it". As an architect, he said, it's rare that you get to apply all sustainable principles "in one go on a city". That's exactly what happened when the King of Bhutan invited him to Gelephu and "asked us to think with him about making an entirely new administrative zone that could be attractive for the younger generations, but based on the principles of Bhutan"—the world's first carbon-negative country.

So, he took the nine measures of Bhutan's Gross National Happiness Index, translating them into design principles for the mindfulness city, to span over 1,000 sq. km. Picture this: neighbourhoods almost like rice fields that cascade down the Himalayan hills, bridges turned into public buildings, the airport itself a bridge crossing three rivers, and a dam—with its entire facade designed like Indian stepwells—to power the city with renewable energy. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Descending from the Himalayas to the tropical plains, cascading terraced fields will become lively neighbourhoods in Gelephu, Bhutan's 'mindfulness city'
- It will include ecological corridors, allowing elephants and tigers to migrate through the urban setting unencumbered
- The city will have buildings made entirely of mass timber, the greatest natural resource of Bhutan, using the local architectural wisdom